

4

• error theory & fictionalism

So far we have discussed nonnaturalism and expressivism. If you thought that the nonnaturalist's philosophies of language and mind were on the right track but the expressivist's metaphysics was roughly right, then you might be on your way towards endorsing some kind of error theory or fictionalism. The basic idea is to agree with the nonnaturalist that basic ethical statements¹ *purport to* represent a special sort of fact that is not plausibly construed as part of the natural world, but then also to agree with the expressivist's antirealist stance towards such putative facts. This means that you think all basic ethical statements are literally false. A similar way to get to this conclusion is if you think that morality presupposes the commands of a divine being but you come to think there is no such thing as a divine being. Then you might conclude that basic ethical statements are *trying* to say something true but they systematically fail. Similarly, error-theorists about ethical discourse think there are no ethical properties and so basic ethical statements are all erroneous. That is to say, error-theorists think ethical discourse presupposes an erroneous view about what kind of facts there are. In this it's like seventeenth-century discourse about Salem witches casting spells or eighteenth-century discourse about phlogiston.

The examples of discourse about witches and phlogiston suggest that the error-theorist will adopt an eliminativist stance about ethical discourse: we should stop talking in ways that presuppose a false metaphysical view about what's real. However, a softer stance is available in fictionalism, which has been imported from the philosophy of mathematics (and also applied in other areas). In metaethics, the core idea is to argue that basic ethical sentences are literally false but also that ethical discourse should be interpreted on the model of a **convenient fiction**. For example, one might think that the sun doesn't literally rise over the horizon and objects moving down an inclined plane never do so frictionlessly; but it is still convenient for many purposes to talk as if these things are true. In effect, discourse about these things may contain a lot of literally false sentences but as long as we realize this, it can be convenient for various purposes to pretend these sentences are true. Metaethical fictionalists think something similar about ethical discourse.²

Key Point: Error-theorists and fictionalists in metaethics agree with realists that ethical thought is cognitive and ethical language is representational, but they argue that it never succeeds in correctly describing reality and so is erroneous or part of a false but convenient fiction.

In this chapter, I'll introduce some famous arguments for error theory due to J. L. Mackie and consider some possible objections. Then I'll canvass some different forms of fictionalism, explaining why their proponents think they are better than eliminativist forms of error theory and how proponents of other metaethical views might object to them.

• MACKIE'S ARGUMENTS FOR ERROR THEORY

Any error theory must have two parts:

- 1 A positive conceptual/semantic claim: ethical discourse purports to be about objective ethical values or facts.
- 2 A negative metaphysical claim: objective ethical values or facts don't exist or obtain.

QUI: Which of the following is a positive conceptual/semantic claim about mathematics: (i) there are no numbers, (ii) mathematics is a merely symbolic exercise not even trying to represent objective facts?

Philosophers such as Plato (via Thrasymachus in *Republic I*) and Nietzsche introduced error-theoretic ideas about morality, but Mackie is widely credited with providing a contemporary and systematic defence of the view in the first chapter of his book *Ethics: Inventing Right and Wrong* (1977). He provides several arguments but separates them under two headings: the **argument from relativity**, the **argument from queerness**.

The argument from relativity proceeds from the observation that there is widespread ethical disagreement around the world. For example, in some cultures, one must bury the dead, in others the dead are burned. Some cultures require women to wear headscarfs in public, others forbid it in certain professional contexts. Mackie claims that the best explanation of this variation of ethical opinion is that people participate in different ways of life; and they tend to approve of those ways of life in which they participate. If this is right, then it would seem that people disagree about ethics not because one culture is getting it right and others are getting it wrong, rather the disagreement is simply a manifestation of different cultural norms.

By itself, however, this argument doesn't establish the error theory. This is because—even if we agree that it is sound—it only supports the negative metaphysical claim,

not the positive conceptual/semantic claim needed for an error theory. To see this, notice that expressivists such as Ayer could agree that people disagree about ethics not because one culture is getting it right and others are getting it wrong, rather the disagreement is simply a manifestation of different cultural norms. But they would argue that ethical discourse doesn't even purport to be about objective ethical values or facts, but rather is an expression of our commitment to our own values. Moreover, as we'll see in the following chapter, some naturalists in metaethics argue that there are ethical facts but they are facts about the customs and practices in different cultures, which means that they are relative not objective. Such a relativist could agree with Mackie's argument from relativity. Because expressivism and relativism are equally natural responses to Mackie's argument for relativity, in the discussion about error theory, his second argument—the argument from queerness—has received much more attention.

There are several versions of the argument we might glean from Mackie's text. They all begin by arguing for the positive conceptual/semantic claim mentioned above—viz. that ethical discourse purports to be about objective ethical values or facts. Here's roughly how the argument goes:

First, Mackie suggests that commonsense morality presupposes that ethical values are **intrinsically motivating** in the sense that someone recognizing that an action is good/bad would be drawn towards doing/avoiding it. That is to say, we do things to promote the good and avoid the bad—at least in part—*because* we know they are good/bad and not because of some antecedent desire we happen to have (e.g., to be seen in a certain light by our community or to be in a position to claim moral superiority over others). (This is related to the motivational internalist view I introduced in Chapter 1.)

Second, Mackie suggests that commonsense morality presupposes that ethical facts are **objectively prescriptive** in the sense that they generate universal reasons for people to do things, reasons which are independent of people's particular desires, cares, or concerns. For example, many people agree that torture is bad, and not just bad for satisfying someone's desires or concerns, but *really* bad irrespective of people's particular desires, cares, or concerns. In this case, for example, Mackie would suggest that we are presupposing that the badness of torture gives everyone an objective reason for action (of e.g., not torturing, preventing others from torturing) and not just a reason that is relative to this or that contingent set of desires, cares, or concerns. (This is related to the externalist thesis about justifying reasons that I introduced in Chapter 1; and it will be relevant for understanding relativist forms of naturalist realism that I will discuss in Chapter 5.)³

Those two claims pertain to the positive conceptual part of Mackie's error theory. Next, he turns to the negative metaphysical part of the theory, arguing that careful reflection reveals that there aren't facts that could intrinsically motivate and/or objectively prescribe. One reason he gives for this is epistemological in character. He thinks that if there were such facts and sometimes we know them, then we would

have to possess a special faculty by which we come to perceive/recognize them—what Moore called the “faculty of moral intuition.” But Mackie thought it was very implausible that we have such a faculty: it’d be nothing like vision, hearing, smell, or even our faculty of reason. This doesn’t show that there are no ethical facts, but it puts the burden of proof on someone who claims that there are such facts. Another reason he gives for doubting the existence of ethical facts is metaphysical in character. He thinks that if there were intrinsically motivating and/or objectively prescriptive facts, then they would be wholly unlike any other kind of fact whose existence we recognize. As he puts it, objective values would have to have “to be doneness” built into them, but in light of our modern scientific worldview we should view that putative feature of reality as “queer.”

QU2: What gives Mackie’s first reason an “epistemological” character and his second reason a “metaphysical” character?

A final reason he gives for thinking would-be objective ethical facts are queer is based on the concept of supervenience, which we encountered in the previous chapter. Like many other metaethicists, Mackie assumes that ethical value (were it to exist) would as a matter of necessity have to be distinct from but supervene on the natural features of an action. Recall the intuition that there could be no *mere* difference between the value of two actions; to differ in their ethical properties, there would have to be some underlying difference in their natural properties. However, Mackie thought it would be a very queer fact that could be distinct from the natural and yet necessarily supervene on it. (This is essentially the objection from supervenience against nonnaturalism we encountered in Chapter 2.)

• OBJECTIONS AND REPLIES

There are not many philosophers who agree with the error theory. The simplest and perhaps most pervasive reason for this is that they are strongly convinced of their mostly deeply held ethical beliefs—e.g., that genocide is wrong, that charity is good, etc. and the error-theorist’s position seems to imply that these beliefs are all false because based on a metaphysical error. Surely, one might think, no theoretical argument in metaethics could convince us that genocide is not wrong or that charity is not good! (This is similar to the Moorean response to radical external world skepticism: surely, no theoretical argument in epistemology could convince us that we know *nothing* of what we think we know about reality!)

It’s important, however, to avoid a common mistake. True, error-theorists deny that genocide is objectively wrong and that charity is objectively good, but they also don’t think that genocide is objectively *right* or that charity is objectively *bad*. That’s because they deny that any actions have any such basic ethical properties whatsoever.

Moreover, they typically share our moral sensibilities. That is, they find genocide abhorrent, charity laudable, etc. They are not amoral; and they are generally no more immoral than the rest of us. So, we shouldn't confuse our feelings about things like genocide and charity with reasons to disagree with the error theory.

Nevertheless, the error-theorist's position can seem to do violence to ordinary discourse. Just as much as we talk as if statements about the external world are often true, we talk as if statements about morality are often true. And many philosophers think we should theorize under a **principle of charity**, which suggests that we should start out from the assumption that most of what people assert is true, and if it seems as if someone is making lots of false assertions, then we should reconsider whether we properly understand the meaning of what they are saying. Error-theorists think that ethical statements purport to be about facts that are intrinsically motivating for those who recognize them and objectively prescriptive for all of us. But if that means that lots of what we assert is false, then perhaps error-theorists should reconsider their interpretation of what ethical statements purport to be about.

Mackie has two avenues for responding to this worry. First, he (or at least a sympathetic interpreter⁴) might argue that in his view it's not ordinary ethical statements that come out false but the presupposition they commonly carry, viz. that ethical values are intrinsically motivating and objectively prescriptive. It's a vexed issue in the philosophy of language whether statements with a false presupposition should be counted as false, truth-value-less, or just odd. So if Mackie insisted on this, it would avoid him counting most of what people say when engaged in ethical discourse as false (though he'd still be committed to its manifesting some kind of pernicious ontological error). Second, in Mackie's book he argues that there's a very good reason that we tend to objectify our ethical values. Those values aren't whimsical preferences but rather commitments around which we try to coordinate our behavior in community with other people. As such, there is a strong practical motive for speaking and thinking as if there really are objective ethical facts: that's the best way to achieve coordination with one another around our ethical principles. Here, the idea behind his argument from relativity might be thought to help. Part of the reason we want there to be objectively right answers about matters of ethical controversy is precisely that there is disagreement and this disagreement matters for how we live with one another. Still, we may worry that this cuts both ways. Insofar as one recognizes the variability of ethical views across the world and the intractability of many disputes about those views, wouldn't one be inclined to reconsider whether those views are really about some objective realm of facts which (if we could only ascertain them) would settle the disputes once and for all?

A more specific way to challenge the error theory is to object to the idea that recognizing an action as good/bad would be intrinsically motivating. Recall that this is part of Mackie's positive conceptual/semantic claim about what ordinary ethical discourse presupposes. However, it is not obviously true. As we saw in Chapter 2, some philosophers deny motivational internalism, arguing that at least some ethical

judgments are compatible with no particular motivational propensities. For instance, when we make ethical judgments about things that don't seem particularly connected to our actions, it is less intuitive to think that those judgments necessarily motivate us to act in particular ways. Assume, for example, that you know that it was wrong for Germany to invade the Soviet Union in 1941. Does that mean that you are motivated to act in any particular way? There isn't anything you can do about that now, and it's not like you are going to be in the position of Germany. Why do you think such ethical knowledge would have to be intrinsically motivating?

There are two responses available for error-theorists. First, they could argue that even if it's only the relatively small class of ethical judgments about our own potential future actions that are presumed to be intrinsically motivating by commonsense morality, that's still a commitment that has queer consequences for metaphysics. Second, they could argue that Mackie was wrong to include the assumption that ethical values would have to be intrinsically motivating as a presupposition of ethical discourse, but that still leaves objective prescriptivity, which is more plausibly construed as a presupposition of ordinary ethical discourse.

Recall that "objective prescriptivity" referred to the idea that ethical facts (if any actually obtain) would provide objective reasons for people to do things, i.e. that are independent of those people's particular desires, cares, and concerns. Mackie's idea that there couldn't be such things is related to the internalist view about reasons we discussed in Chapter 1. Indeed, although he doesn't give it a name, Mackie appears to accept this view. After all, part of his argument for saying that ethical facts would be queer, were they to exist, is that they would have to have the power to generate reasons to act which are not connected to our desires, cares, and concerns. But there's a different conclusion we might draw: that all of this just shows that morality is not objectively prescriptive. Maybe each of us has our own personal cares and concerns, but there are some very general principles that are such that, if we all aim to live by them, we will each do a better job promoting our own personal cares and concerns. If that were so, morality might be grounded in each of us having personal cares and concerns that are structured such that we all need to follow some moral principles to promote those cares and concerns. In this way, morality might still count as *universal* in the sense that it generates the same reasons for everyone. However, as long as the reason-giving power of ethical facts depended on people's desires, cares, and concerns, we wouldn't have to say that there was "to-be doneness" somehow contained in the facts themselves. These facts would generate reasons for each of us to do things because of how they connect with our personal desires, cares, and concerns.

QU3: Which kind of "internalism" is related to "objective prescriptivity" and which is related to "intrinsically motivating"?

I want to mention one last way some have objected to the error theory. Recall that Mackie gives epistemological and metaphysical reasons for thinking that objective

ethical values and facts, were they to exist, would be queer. There is a response to both of these sometimes called the **partners-in-crime response**. The idea is to point out that there are other kinds of things that we commonly take ourselves to know, and these raise exactly the same worries: if raising these worries is a philosophical “crime”, they are partners in the crime. If this is right, it generates a dilemma for error-theorists. Either they have to extend the error theory to the other kinds of things too, or they have to abandon their error theory about ethical facts.

A common partner is mathematical facts. For example, Mackie argues that in order to know ethical values and facts, we’d have to have some special faculty for discovering them. But you might say the same thing about knowing facts of arithmetic, geometry, and calculus. These, it seems, aren’t known through vision, hearing, smell, etc. It’s unclear how they’re known, but we ordinarily assume that there is some way to come to know these facts. Moreover, mathematical facts, if there are indeed such, have somewhat weird features. For example, they’re abstract not concrete. And they would seem to hold of necessity. One might think these features are just as “queer” as to-be-doneness. Do error-theorists want to throw out mathematics with morality? Usually not, which means that they owe us an account of mathematical facts and knowledge that shows them not to be partners in the crime of which they charge morality.

Another way to pursue the partners-in-crime response would be by highlighting the distinction between *ethical* reasons and values, and other sorts of reasons and values. For example, we commonly assume that there can be objective reasons to *believe* something and that it’s intellectually valuable to know and understand things. These are *epistemic* facts and values: does the error-theorist want to deny their existence as well? If so, it seems that he’d be paradoxically committed to denying the existence of objective reasons for believing his theory and denying the value of knowing and understanding things about the epistemology and ontology of ethics!

• VERSIONS OF FICTIONALISM

In metaethics, fictionalism emerged as a view inspired by error theory but with somewhat more sophisticated resources for avoiding some of the extreme consequences of error theory. To understand different versions of fictionalism it is helpful to distinguish declarative sentences (the words themselves) from their use to make assertions. Consider, for instance, the sentence:

(1) Holmes lives on Baker Street.

Suppose first that you really know someone named Holmes, and I ask you where he lives; you might use (1) in order to assert that the person you know lives on Baker Street. And if we assume that you are being sincere, then that assertion expresses your belief that Holmes lives on Baker street. Next, however, suppose that we are in an English seminar discussing the works of Arthur Conan Doyle, and I ask you where his main character lives. In this case you might also use (1), but now it is less

clear what you are doing. Here are two possibilities: (i) you are asserting that *in the fiction of Doyle's stories* the character called Holmes lives on Baker Street; and assuming that you are being sincere, that assertion expresses your belief that, in the fiction, this character lives on that street; (ii) your utterance shouldn't be interpreted as an assertion at all but rather as a different kind of speech-act of "talking within a fictional context" or engaging in "pretense" of some sort.⁵ On the first possibility, the idea is that the sentence you have explicitly uttered is somehow incomplete or elliptical for what you're actually asserting. It's similar to when one says "it's raining" but means that it is raining in the place where they are located. On the second possibility, the idea is to take the sentence at face value but construe the speech-act of using the sentence as doing something other than asserting. It's similar to when someone says something like "I'm so hungry I could eat a horse." They're not really asserting that they could eat a horse; rather they're doing something else (exaggerating for effect).

These two possibilities correspond to two different fictionalist positions one could take up in metaethics. Some fictionalists argue that the relevant uses of ethical sentences are assertions about what's true *in a fiction*; others argue that these utterances shouldn't be interpreted as assertions at all but rather pieces of pretense. To appreciate the difference, consider the sentence:

(2) Lying is wrong.

Imagine someone uses (2) in an ethical context, for example while explaining to a child why they shouldn't lie. The first kind of fictionalists, who we could refer to as **meaning fictionalists** hold that the meaning of this statement is more complex than the surface sentence would suggest. They think the person using it has asserted that, according to the fiction of morality, lying is wrong. So, while the sentence on the page is literally false, the asserted content is true; the beliefs expressed by typical utterances of that sentence are true (because they are implicitly about a fiction). The second kind of fictionalists, who we could refer to as **speech-act fictionalists** would hold that this statement is not appropriately interpreted as an assertion at all. Rather it is some other kind of speech-act, such as pretense or make-believe. On this view, someone who says (2) has said something literally false but they have not *asserted* a falsehood because they haven't asserted anything at all. Rather, they have engaged in a pretense.

QU4: Consider the statement "The sun rises in the morning." What's the difference between meaning fictionalism and speech-act fictionalism about this statement?

Notice how both forms of fictionalism offer ways to respect the principle of charity that seemed to be violated by the error theory. Because fictionalists agree that there aren't really any ethical values or facts, they think basic ethical sentences such

as (2) are literally false. However, rather than charging that most of what ordinary people assert about morality is false, fictionalists propose a more nuanced interpretation of ethical discourse. Meaning fictionalists suggest that the propositions we are asserting are more complicated (in being tacitly relativized to a fiction) than the surface sentences suggest. Speech-act fictionalists suggest that we aren't really asserting propositions, but rather pretending.

Key Point: Like error-theorists, fictionalists hold that basic ethical sentences are literally false (because there are no ethical facts to make them true). However, unlike error-theorists, fictionalists think that ordinary ethical discourse is in order: those sentences aren't used to assert false propositions but rather to do something else (assert more complex true propositions or engage in a form of pretense).

One serious challenge for meaning fictionalists is that it seems ad hoc and counter-intuitive to say that someone who uses (2) to make a statement in a moral context has asserted something about a fiction. This is because there doesn't seem to be any basis for thinking normal users of this sentence are talking about fictions (except, perhaps, for the theoretically self-serving reason of salvaging something like the error theory in light of the principle of charity). After all, unlike the statements about where Holmes lives, most people who make ethical statements don't take themselves to be asserting things about some fiction. Moreover, it is highly unclear which fiction we should say they are asserting things about—there are many possible moralities.

Because of this, speech-act fictionalism is perhaps better represented among meta-ethicists today. Kalderon (2005) develops a version of this which promises also to be able to capture some of the intuitive attraction of the expressivist idea that ethical statements function to express positive and negative attitudes in the attempt to coordinate our emotional responses to the world with our community. In the characterization above, I said that speech-act fictionalists hold that ethical statements aren't assertions, and so they are not the expression of beliefs but rather pieces of pretense. So far that's mostly negative and vague. It doesn't yet tell us what ethical statements do express if they don't express beliefs. Kalderon argues that although ethical *sentences* are representational and so truth-apt in a perfectly robust sense, the standard use of them to perform a *speech-act* is expressive rather than representational. That is, much like the expressivists, he thinks ethical statements express positive and negative attitudes. If this is right, then he has just as good an explanation as the expressivist of the apparently tight connection between accepting an ethical statement and motivation to act (however tight this turns out to be, which may not be perfectly tight).

One thing to think about, however, is how plausible it is to claim that we express these attitudes by systematically uttering falsehoods. When it comes to other paradigmatically fictional discourses, we can imagine someone interrupting and saying, "Wait, the sentence you uttered is literally false. You don't mean that Holmes *really*

lives on Baker Street, do you?” and this being followed by an impatient “No, I mean to be speaking from within the fiction; we’re just pretending.” But now imagine someone interrupted a piece of ethical discourse saying, “Wait, the sentence you just uttered is literally false. You don’t mean that genocide is *really* wrong, do you?” Many people would be inclined to respond, “Yes, indeed, that’s what I mean.”

• CONCLUSION

Error-theorists in metaethics defend two connected claims: (i) a positive conceptual/semantic claim about ethical discourse to the effect that its sentences represent facts with special features such as involving intrinsically motivating values and/or objectively prescriptive facts, (ii) a negative metaphysical claim to the effect that such things don’t really exist. In this error-theorists agree with the semantics of nonnaturalism but the metaphysics of expressivism. The most prominent arguments for the error theory come in the various versions of what Mackie called the “argument from queerness.” However, many philosophers have felt that something must be wrong about Mackie’s error theory, because it so drastically violates the principle of charity.

A way to avoid violating the principle of charity while still endorsing (i) and (ii) is to take a fictionalist rather than eliminativist stance towards ethical discourse. Meaning fictionalists argue that, although ethical sentences are literally false, what people mean when using them to make assertions is something more complicated about the fiction of morality. Speech-act fictionalists, by contrast, argue that ordinary use of ethical sentences is not assertoric but rather a kind of pretense, perhaps one by which we express our moral attitudes. Even if some version of fictionalism can better respect the principle of charity than eliminativist forms of the error theory, we may still worry that they don’t do a very good job respecting our ordinary self-conception of what we are up to when we engage in ethical discourse.

• CHAPTER SUMMARY

- Error-theorists and fictionalists defend two claims: a positive conceptual/semantic claim and a negative metaphysical claim.
- Mackie famously offered the “argument from relativity” and the “argument from queerness” for the error theory.
- There are epistemological and metaphysical versions of the argument from queerness.
- Mackie’s error theory is based on the conceptual claim that ethical discourse is about intrinsically motivating values and objectively prescriptive facts, but both of these are controversial ideas that opponents of the error theory might argue against.
- Even if one endorses the two claims of an ethical error theory, one needn’t take an eliminativist stance towards ethical discourse; this is because one can develop some form of fictionalism.

- Two forms of fictionalism are meaning fictionalism and speech-act fictionalism. The former says that ethical statements are assertions about what's true in the fiction of morality. The latter says that moral statements aren't assertions at all, but rather forms of pretense.

• STUDY QUESTIONS

- 1 Explain Mackie's argument from relativity. Why doesn't this fully support error theory?
- 2 What's the difference between the epistemological and metaphysical versions of Mackie's argument from queerness?
- 3 What is "objective to-be-doneness" and why would someone call it "queer"?
- 4 How is the argument from queerness related to the argument for expressivism from naturalism and Hume's Law?
- 5 What is the difference between eliminativism and fictionalism in the context of metaethical error theory?
- 6 Which better respects the principle of charity, meaning fictionalism or speech-act fictionalism?

• FURTHER RESOURCES

- Joyce, Richard. 2009. "Moral Anti-Realism," *The Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy* (Summer 2009 Edition), Edward N. Zalta, (ed.), <http://plato.stanford.edu/archives/sum2009/entries/moral-anti-realism>. [Contains a significant section on error theory, including a supplement discussing the particulars of Mackie's arguments for error theory.]
- Joyce, Richard. 2013. "Error Theory," in LaFollette, H. (ed.), *The International Encyclopedia of Ethics*. Blackwell: 1709–1716. [Concise explanation of moral error theory.]
- Kalderon, Mark. 2005. *Moral Fictionalism*. Oxford University Press. [Monograph-length development of speech-act fictionalism.]
- Mabrito, Robert. 2013. "Fictionalism, Moral," in LaFollette, H. (ed.), *The International Encyclopedia of Ethics*. Blackwell: 1972–1981. [Concise explanation of moral fictionalism, including a discussion of revolutionary fictionalism.]
- Olson, Jonas. 2011. "In Defense of Moral Error Theory," in Brady, M. (ed.), *New Waves in Metaethics*. Palgrave Macmillan: 62–84. [A careful study of several arguments in favor of moral error theory.]

• ANSWERS TO QUESTIONS OF UNDERSTANDING

- QU1: (ii) is the conceptual/semantic claim as it's about mathematical thought and discourse rather than (directly) about what is real.

- QU2: The first reason is about what it would take to *know* ethical facts, and epistemology is about knowledge. The second reason is about what ethical facts would have to be like, and metaphysics is about what various pieces of reality are like.
- QU3: Internalism about justifying reasons is a thesis about what it takes for morality to generate reasons for people (it must connect to their cares and concerns), and so it is related to “objective prescriptivity.” More specifically, if internalism about justifying reasons is true, it’s difficult (though perhaps not impossible) to see how there could be objectively prescriptive facts. By contrast, motivational internalism is a thesis about the psychological role of ethical judgments. For ethical facts (assuming there are any) to be “intrinsically motivating,” our belief in them would have to have the power to motivate action independently of any desires we have.
- QU4: The meaning fictionalist thinks the actual sentence used is incomplete and so literally false, but the use of this sentence to make a statement should be seen as an assertion of some more complex proposition, such as that the sun rises in the morning *in the fiction*. This proposition is true. By contrast, the speech-act fictionalist denies that this statement is an assertion of any proposition; instead she thinks it is some other kind of speech-act, such as *pretending*.

• WORKS CITED

- Joyce, Richard. 2001. *The Myth of Morality*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.
- Kalderon, Mark. 2005. *Moral Fictionalism*. Oxford: Oxford University Press.
- Mackie, J. L. 1977. *Ethics: Inventing Right and Wrong*. London: Penguin.
- Stanley, Jason. 2001. “Hermeneutic Fictionalism.” *Midwest Studies in Philosophy* 25 (1): 36–71.

• NOTES

- 1 This reference to *basic* ethical statements is meant to avoid a complication in talking about ethical statements quite generally, i.e. to include logically complex ethical statements. If “Murder is wrong” is a basic statement, then “Murder is *not* wrong” and “Murder is good *or* bad” are non-basic statements because of the presence of logical words such as ‘not’ and ‘or.’ Error-theorists and fictionalists typically don’t claim that statements such as “Murder is not good” are false. This is not because they think murder *is* good but because they think *nothing* is good or bad. Similarly, they won’t say that a statement such as “If murder is bad, then charity is good” is false, but that’s again because they think nothing is good or bad.
- 2 A distinction is sometimes drawn between “hermeneutic” and “revolutionary” forms of fictionalism (Stanley, 2001), where the former is part of a descriptive project of explaining what some area of discourse is actually like and the latter is part of a normative project of explaining how we should alter or change our use of some area of discourse. So, you might think that ethical discourse isn’t actually understood as convenient fiction but that it should be, in which case you’d be a revolutionary fictionalist. In this chapter, I ignore revolutionary fictionalism. This is because it does not directly compete with the other main metaethical views, which are all parts of the descriptive project of trying to explain what ethical discourse (and thought, and reality) are like. For a sustained defense of revolutionary fictionalism and discussion of related issues, see Joyce (2001).
- 3 Although Mackie thought both the intrinsic motivational character and the objectively prescriptive character of ethical discourse are features of the commonsensical conception of morality,

it's useful to distinguish them because we'll see below that it's controversial whether ethical discourse presupposes that ethical facts (if there are any) would be intrinsically motivating for those who recognize them. And it's also controversial whether ethical discourse presupposes that ethical values are objectively prescriptive for all of us. However, if just one of these characterizations of the presuppositions of ordinary ethical discourse is correct, then it puts an error-theorist in a position to argue for the negative metaphysical part of his error theory.

4 Selim Berker convinced me this is a possible interpretation of Mackie's text.

5 It's important to note that the idea in calling this "pretense" is not that you are *intentionally* pretending but rather that the language you are using isn't to be taken as literally asserting something. Compare an ordinary use of the sentence "The sun rose at 5am." Plausibly, for anyone who knows that the location of the sun in the sky is caused by the earth's rotation rather than the sun's levitation, a use of this sentence isn't appropriately treated as an assertion but rather as a kind of pretense or loose speak. However, we needn't think such people are intentionally pretending.